

Trees & Greenery

Trees in the park in January

Most are standing bare of leaves, but there are some evergreens.

A spruce or fir tree? When it has cones, that would help identify which fir tree this is

Pagans used branches of fir to decorate their homes during the winter solstice and certainly during the 16th century Christians in Germany brought fir trees into their homes to decorate for Christmas.



But there's a lot of greenery as well as the grass



For starters there's the privet hedge in Dr Jack's. It might well be evergreen but there are lots of species of privet ranging from deciduous to evergreen so maybe not.



In amongst the privet is a very welcome sight
Hazel Catkins or Lambs' Tails

the very early, sometimes before Christmas, sign of spring. With its magical tree reputation, a hazel rod could be defence against evil spirits as well as a water diviner.

And another bush that still has green leaves is the bramble. Very competitive, it's well adapted to acquire all it needs – water, nutrients and light, at the expense of other species. It's not called one of nature's survivors for nothing.

However, it's a good source of food for many creatures – not forgetting blackberries for us!



You just have to wait about 8 months!

Trees & Greenery

The prize for providing the most green in our winter park goes to the ivy

Hedera helix is one of UK's few native evergreen plants and it's everywhere.

The different leaves look as if they come from different species but no, that's not the reason.

The juvenile leaf is quite different from the mature leaf. (Bit like us really!)

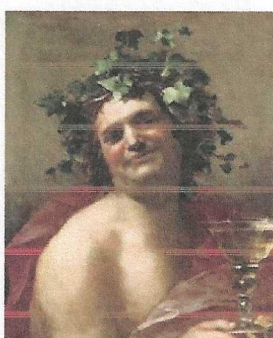


Juvenile



Mature

Yet another plant to bring indoors to keep evil spirits at bay, and something to remember - wearing a wreath of ivy leaves around your head is supposed to stop you getting drunk!



Bacchus wears one



as does a priestess of Bacchus

There's lots of talk about whether ivy strangles trees or not and on the other hand maybe it should be celebrated for providing food and shelter for wildlife and

green in our winter months



Trees & Greenery

More green from the nettles in the hedgerow



The nettle is our only common stinging plant

But do they sting in winter? **Over to you . . . !**



ferns in the wood



And what a surprise a hellebore!

Back to the evergreens - we have one holly tree



- Our traditional Christmas decoration goes back to pagan times, well before Christianity, when holly boughs were brought in to deck the house. After all, it was a powerful fertility symbol and a charm against witches and evil spirits and it was unlucky to cut a holly tree down.
- Christianity adopted the holly customs and in the carol *The Holly and the Ivy* the holly represents Jesus and the ivy the Virgin Mary.
- It's seen as a very masculine plant – “the holly wears the crown” – but what is conveniently forgotten is that the trees with berries are always female!
- Harry Potter's wand is made from holly

January

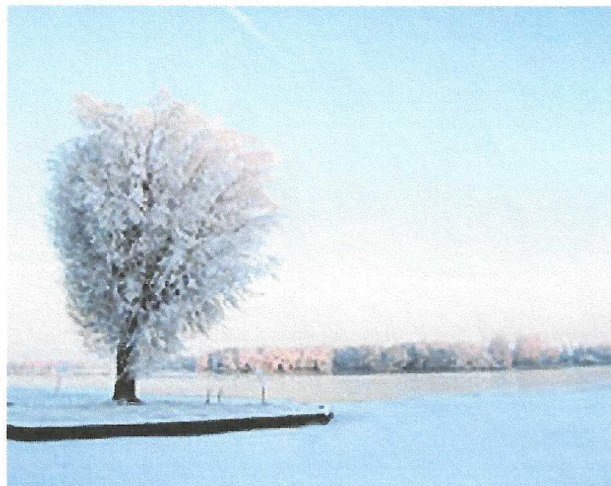
And some Did You Know? facts about January

- ❖ At one time there were only 10 months in the year, March being the first month
- ❖ After the celebratory rituals of the winter solstice came the famine months until spring
- ❖ Sometime during what was the Iron Age in Europe, from about 800 BC onwards, Rome added January and February to their calendar
- ❖ January was named *Ianuarius* after *ianus*, Latin for door – the door to the year and new beginnings
- ❖ *Wulf-monath* was its Saxon name
- ❖ *Wintarmanoth* was its name in the time of Charlemagne, who by the way united much of western and central Europe during the Early Middle Ages
- ❖ Its birthstone is the garnet



- ❖ Its flower the snowdrop

Will we have snow?



January

❄️ January brings the snow ❄️
❄️ Makes our feet and fingers glow ❄️

And if not, it certainly brings lots of other things!

1st January

New Year's Day After the New Year's Eve celebrations if you've still got energy there are plenty of football matches and swims in ice-cold water

6th January

Twelfth Night Christmas decorations down. Does anyone still make a 12th Night cake?

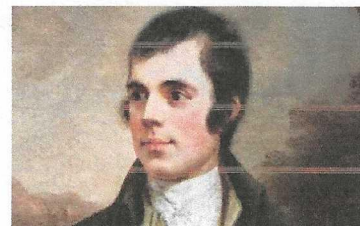
Epiphany The presentation of Jesus to the Gentiles, and there is such a thing as an Epiphany cake

Three Kings Day Dia de los Reyes is the day most children in Spain and the Spanish-speaking countries receive their presents. They leave their shoes outside the door and of course there's a cake – a pastry ring shaped like a crown, topped with glazed fruits and there's a hidden toy inside

25th January

Burns Night when we celebrate Robbie Burns' birthday starting with the Selkirk Grace

Some hae meat an canna eat,
And some wad eat that want it;
But we hae meat, and we can eat,
And sae the Lord be thankit



After a Scottish soup the address to the Haggis (too long to write out here) begins, and at the appropriate line a knife is plunged into the haggis and it's cut end to end.



Then after a whisky toast the haggis is served with tatties and neeps

And the whole finished off with *Auld Lang Syne*

There must be more celebratory January days in other countries?